The Hindu
EDITORIAL ANALYSIS

5th February 2025

PREPARE FOR BANK (PO/ CLERK), SSC,UPSC, State PSC, CAT,CTET,RAILWAY EXAMS,CDS, TET, NDA/AIRFORCE, NET and all Govt. Exams

VOCABULARY

1. Turmoil (अशांति)

Meaning: A state of great disturbance, confusion, or uncertainty.
Synonyms: Chaos, disorder, upheaval
Antonyms: Peace, stability, order
Example: The ongoing turmoil surrounding USAID is expected to impact WHO's funding.

2. Keenness (उत्सुकता)

Meaning: The quality of being eager, enthusiastic, or highly interested.
Synonyms: Enthusiasm, eagerness, zeal
Antonyms: Indifference, apathy, disinterest
Example: The government's keenness on implementing the NEP is evident from its increased focus on early education.

VOCABULARY

3. Prerequisite (पूर्वापेक्षा)

Meaning: A thing that is required as a prior condition for something else to happen or exist.
Synonyms: Requirement, necessity, essential
Antonyms: Optional, unnecessary, nonessential
Example: Achieving foundational literacy is a prerequisite for building a highly skilled workforce.

4. Sapped (धीरे-धीरे कमजोर होना)

Meaning: Gradually weaken or destroy (a person's strength or power).
Synonyms: Drained, depleted, exhausted
Antonyms: Energized, invigorated, strengthened
Example: The long hours of work sapped his energy.

VOCABULARY

5. Overhauling (पुनर्निर्माण)

Meaning: The process of taking apart and improving or repairing something.
Synonyms: Revamping, renovating, refurbishing
Antonyms: Neglecting, damaging, harming
Example: The company is overhauling its entire production system to improve efficiency.

6. Veil (नक़ाब)

Meaning: A piece of fine material worn to cover the face; also used metaphorically to describe something that conceals or disguises.
Synonyms: Mask, curtain, shroud
Antonyms: Reveal, expose, uncover
Example: The company's financial problems were hidden behind a veil of secrecy.

VOCABULARY

7. Contemporaneous (एक समय में होना)

Meaning: Existing or occurring in the same period of time.
Synonyms: Concurrent, coexisting, simultaneous
Antonyms: Asynchronous, non-simultaneous, successive
Example: The two events were contemporaneous, leading to a busy week.

8. Culminating (चरम पर पहुँचाना)

Meaning: Reach a climax or point of highest development.
Synonyms: Concluding, reaching, ending
Antonyms: Beginning, starting, commencing
Example: The tensions culminated in a violent confrontation.

VOCABULARY

9. Dissipation (नष्ट होना)

Meaning: The process of slowly disappearing or being reduced, often through wasteful or inefficient use.
Synonyms: Dispersal, depletion, waste
Antonyms: Accumulation, concentration, preservation
Example: The dissipation of the post-COVID economic boom has led to a more cautious outlook for the future.

10. Lacuna (फ़ासला)

Meaning: An unfilled space or gap, especially a missing portion in a manuscript, text, or idea.
Synonyms: Gap, omission, void, deficiency
Antonyms: Continuity, completeness, fullness
Example: The lacuna in the policy left many citizens confused about their rights.

VOCABULARY

Phrasal Verbs:

1. Wind down
Meaning – To relax or gradually bring something to an end.

2. Get across
Meaning – To successfully communicate or convey a message.

3. Carve out
Meaning – To create or obtain something, often with effort.

4. Rope in
Meaning – To persuade or involve someone in a task or activity.

VOCABULARY

Idioms & Phrases

1. The early bird catches the worm

Meaning: The person who takes the earliest action gets the best results

2. Kill two birds with one stone

Meaning: To accomplish two tasks with a single effort

3. Hold out an olive branch

Meaning: To offer peace or attempt to end a dispute

VOCABULARY

4. Catch someone red-handed

Meaning: To catch someone in the act of doing something wrong or illegal.

5. Roll out the red carpet

Meaning: To give special treatment or a warm welcome, especially to important guests.

Article for Reading

Learning steps: On the Union Budget and education

Besides some high-profile announcements, such as an AI Centre of Excellence for education with an allocation of ₹500 crore, broadband connectivity for schools, the expansion of five third-generation IITs, and increased funding for Indian knowledge systems, Budget 2025 has promised higher allocations for education compared to last year's revised estimates. There was a 7% increase for higher education, although the actual expenditure for 2023-24 was 10% more than the 2025-26 Budget estimates. A key challenge in higher education is that the ambitious UGC reforms, modelled on advanced nations, require significant funding. For instance, introducing four-year degree programmes, allowing students to take courses across multiple institutions, implementing bi-annual admissions, and other structural changes demand substantial finances, which will inevitably fall upon State governments. However, Budget 2025 does not appear to adequately address these financial concerns.

The release of the ASER 2024 report in the same week as the Union Budget highlighted gaps in India's school education system, particularly in foundational literacy and numeracy (FLN). While the report indicated that learning losses from the COVID-19 pandemic have been recovered, and, in some cases, FLN levels are at their highest ever, India still has some way to go before achieving full FLN, the 2026-27 target under the NIPUN Bharat scheme. Compared to the 2024-25 revised estimates (RE), school education has been allocated an additional ₹11,000 crore, a 16% increase. However, as a percentage of the total Budget, this increase is only 0.12 percentage points, bringing the allocation to 1.55%. In higher education, the Budget fraction remains unchanged at 0.99%. While institutions such as Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan continue to receive significant funding, the increase does reflect higher inflows to States, which are the primary implementers of school education programmes.

The Centre has been keen on fully implementing the National Education Policy (NEP), which proposes a 5+3+3+4 system that includes five years of early education up to Class 3. Early education is being prioritised as the key to achieving full FLN, but a critical gap remains: the two years before Class 1 are managed by underpaid anganwadi workers, who are already overburdened and often lack adequate training to deliver on FLN goals. A focused FLN drive is pivotal to achieving full FLN, a prerequisite for building a highly skilled workforce and leveraging India's demographic dividend. Over the next few years, depending on the progress made, the government must further strengthen school education investments to ensure India meets its full FLN target. Time is of the essence.

Summary

Budget 2025 has increased allocations for education, with a 7% rise for higher education and a ₹11,000 crore (16%) increase for school education. However, challenges remain, especially in higher education, where ambitious UGC reforms require more funding than what has been allocated. The ASER 2024 report highlighted progress in foundational literacy and numeracy (FLN) but also underscored the gaps that persist. The National Education Policy (NEP) prioritizes early education, but underpaid and overburdened anganwadi workers pose a challenge to achieving FLN goals. While the budget reflects higher inflows to States, concerns about long-term investments in education remain. The passage emphasizes the need for stronger financial commitments to fully implement FLN initiatives and leverage India's demographic advantage.

Tone:

The tone is analytical and slightly critical. While acknowledging the budgetary increases, the passage points out the inadequacies in funding, particularly in higher education and early education. It stresses the urgency of addressing foundational learning gaps and ensuring effective implementation of education reforms.

Reading Comprehension

Based on the above passage, answer the following questions:

Question 1:
What did the ASER 2024 report reveal about foundational literacy and numeracy (FLN) in India?

a) Learning losses from the COVID-19 pandemic have not yet been recovered.
b) FLN levels have declined significantly in recent years.
c) Learning losses have been recovered, but India is still short of achieving full FLN.
d) India has already achieved its 2026-27 FLN target under NIPUN Bharat.
e) None of the above

Question 2:
Which statement best describes the trend in education budget allocation for 2025?

a) The budget for school education has increased significantly, but higher education remains underfunded.
b) School education has received a moderate increase in funding, while higher education's share remains the same.
c) The overall education budget has declined compared to the previous year.
d) Higher education received a larger percentage increase in funding than school education.
e) None of the above

Question 3:
What is the government's long-term goal in strengthening school education investments?

a) To transition entirely to AI-driven learning methods across schools and colleges.
b) To reduce student dropout rates by implementing the 5+3+3+4 NEP framework.
c) To privatize school education and reduce dependency on government-funded institutions.
d) To ensure India meets its full foundational literacy and numeracy (FLN) target and builds a highly skilled workforce.
e) None of the above

Article for Skimming

The U.S.’s exit from WHO, a chance to reshape global health

On January 20, 2025, the United States government issued an executive order to withdraw from membership of the World Health Organization (WHO). This has raised apprehensions that reduced funding for WHO would impact the functionality of the organisation. However, as the executive decision by the U.S. government has already been made, it is time to reflect on some fundamental questions such as why a single country's exit from WHO is causing so much concern. How can the U.S.'s exit from WHO be converted into an opportunity to create a stronger WHO? Why is there a need for an increasingly greater role of countries in Asia and Africa in global health. To understand the impact of the U.S.'s withdrawal on WHO funding, we need to understand WHO's funding system. There are two broad categories of funding sources. In the first, the assessed contribution (or AC) is a fixed amount each WHO member-state must pay annually as a sort of membership fee. This is what the U.S. President has argued as being disproportionately high (for the U.S.) and cited as one of the reasons for the U.S.'s decision regarding its withdrawal.

The assessed contributions ensure assured funding, which WHO uses to pay the salaries of regular staff, both technical and administrative, and maintain day-to-day functioning. This is the minimum resources the organisation needs to ensure a continuity of operations. The other funding pool is from voluntary contributions (or VC) which comes from a range of donor agencies and additional contributions from WHO member-states. VCs are broadly for projects and other time-bound activities. WHO uses VC funds in the hiring of short-term staff and consultants. However, the problem with VC funds is that these are — as the name suggests — voluntary, always time-bound, linked to specific activities, and, thus, unpredictable. For example, many member-states and donors provide funds for polio elimination, patient safety, primary health care or antimicrobial resistance-related work. These contributions are tight-jacketed and non-transferable to other activities. With the U.S.'s withdrawal from WHO, the VC would also be impacted, as many U.S.-based or U.S.-aligned donors may either reduce, or worse, completely stop the funding to WHO.

As an example, the ongoing turmoil and uncertain fate of USAID would additionally impact WHO funding. Clearly, the financial impact on WHO is likely to be far greater than the direct share of the U.S. government funds for WHO. Another argument given for the U.S.'s withdrawal, which has been used frequently by some others to criticise WHO, is that the organisation is highly bureaucratic, acts slow and is in need of urgent reforms. This is partially true and to be fair in assessment, every global institution needs some reforms and WHO is not any different. In fact, there is far more to WHO's credit than the occasional systemic blips it has faced. In this era of emerging and multi-sectoral challenges such as antimicrobial resistance, climate change, global warming and animal health, increasing re-emergence of diseases and a steep rise in lifestyle diseases, the world needs a stronger WHO, more than ever.

Question 4:
Why does the passage argue that the world needs a stronger WHO?

a) Because global health challenges are becoming more complex and interconnected.
b) Because WHO must replace national health agencies in developing countries.
c) Because WHO funding has been increasing significantly.
d) Because developed nations have withdrawn from health diplomacy.
e) None of the above

Question 5:
According to the passage, how should WHO be assessed fairly?

a) By comparing it with other international health organizations.
b) By acknowledging both its weaknesses and its contributions.
c) By only focusing on its bureaucratic inefficiencies.
d) By allowing nations to individually decide its role.
e) None of the above

Today's Descriptive Question

Original Text:

XPoSat (X-ray Polarimeter Satellite) is India's first dedicated polarimetry mission, designed to study cosmic X-ray sources and their polarization properties. Developed by the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), XPoSat aims to enhance our understanding of high-energy astrophysical phenomena, such as black holes, neutron stars, and pulsars. It marks a significant step in India's space research and contributes to global efforts in X-ray astronomy. The satellite carries two key scientific payloads: POLIX (Polarimeter Instrument in X-rays) and XSPECT (X-ray Spectroscopy and Timing). POLIX, developed by the Raman Research Institute (RRI), will measure the polarization of X-ray sources, providing insights into their geometry and emission mechanisms.

XSPECT, developed by ISRO, will study the spectral and temporal characteristics of these sources, offering a deeper understanding of their behavior.

XPoSat will operate in a low Earth orbit (LEO) and is expected to have a mission life of about five years. By analyzing polarized X-ray emissions, the mission will help scientists explore extreme astrophysical environments and test fundamental theories of high-energy physics.

With XPoSat, India joins an elite group of nations conducting advanced space-based X-ray polarimetry. The mission strengthens India's space capabilities and contributes valuable data to the global scientific community, paving the way for future advancements in astrophysics.

Precis:

XPoSat is India’s first X-ray polarimetry mission by ISRO, designed to study cosmic X-ray sources like black holes and neutron stars. It carries two scientific payloads: POLIX, for measuring X-ray polarization, and XSPECT, for studying spectral and timing properties.

Operating in low Earth orbit, XPoSat will enhance understanding of high-energy astrophysics over its five-year mission. The satellite marks India's entry into advanced X-ray astronomy, contributing valuable scientific data and strengthening its space research capabilities.

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To: ……@gmail.com

Subject: Request for Refund – Defective Product Received (Order ID: [Your Order ID])

Dear [Customer Support Team/Specific Contact Name],

I hope this email finds you well. I recently placed an order on your platform, but unfortunately, I received a defective product. Below are the details of my purchase:

Order ID: [Your Order ID]
Product Name: [Product Name]
Date of Delivery: [Delivery Date]
Upon unboxing, I noticed that [describe the defect—e.g., "the product is not functioning as expected," "there is visible damage," "it is different from the description on the website"].

I have attached relevant photos/videos as evidence of the issue.

As per your refund policy, I kindly request a full refund for this order. Please let me know if you need any additional information or if there are any further steps I should follow to process the refund.

I would appreciate a prompt resolution to this matter. Looking forward to your response.

Best regards,
[Your Name]
[Your Contact Information]

Match the column

1. The early bird catches the worm	A. To offer peace or attempt to end a dispute
2. Kill two birds with one stone	B. The person who takes the earliest action gets the best results
3. Hold out an olive branch	C. To accomplish two tasks with a single effort
4. Catch someone red-handed	D. To give special treatment
5. Roll out the red carpet	E. To catch someone in the act of doing something wrong

Answer:

1-b

2-c

3-a

4-e

5-d

Vocabulary

1. Turmoil:
2. Keenness:
3. Prerequisite:
4. Sapped:
5. Overhauling:
6. Veil:
7. Contemporaneous:
8. Culminating:
9. Dissipation:
10. Lacuna:

Rc ans

1.

Ans: c

Explanation:

Reference: "While the report indicated that learning losses from the COVID-19 pandemic have been recovered, and, in some cases, FLN levels are at their highest ever, India still has some way to go before achieving full FLN, the 2026-27 target under the NIPUN Bharat scheme."

The passage states that learning losses from COVID-19 have been recovered, and in some cases, FLN levels are at their highest ever. However, India has not yet reached full FLN, which is targeted for 2026-27 under NIPUN Bharat.

Incorrect Options:

a) Learning losses have been recovered.
b) FLN levels are at their highest ever in some cases, so they have not declined.
d) The target is for 2026-27, and India is not there yet.

2.

Ans: b

Explanation:

Reference: "Compared to the 2024-25 revised estimates (RE), school education has been allocated an additional ₹11,000 crore, a 16% increase. However, as a percentage of the total Budget, this increase is only 0.12 percentage points, bringing the allocation to 1.55%. In higher education, the Budget fraction remains unchanged at 0.99%."

The passage states that school education received an additional ₹11,000 crore, a 16% increase, but as a fraction of the total budget, it rose only by 0.12 percentage points to 1.55%. Higher education's share remains unchanged at 0.99%.

Incorrect Options:

a) Higher education funding has increased by 7%, but its budget fraction remains unchanged.
c) The budget has increased, not declined.
d) The percentage increase for school education (16%) is higher than for higher education (7%).

3.

Ans: d

Explanation:

Reference: "A focused FLN drive is pivotal to achieving full FLN, a prerequisite for building a highly skilled workforce and leveraging India’s demographic dividend."

The passage states that achieving full FLN is crucial because it serves as a prerequisite for building a highly skilled workforce and leveraging India's demographic dividend.

Incorrect Options:

a) AI-driven learning is mentioned, but not as the primary goal.
b) The NEP is a reform framework, but the ultimate goal is FLN.
c) The passage does not mention privatization.

4.
Ans: a
Explanation:
Reference: "In this era of emerging and multi-sectoral challenges such as antimicrobial resistance, climate change, global warming and animal health, increasing re-emergence of diseases and a steep rise in lifestyle diseases, the world needs a stronger WHO, more than ever."

The passage highlights emerging and multi-sectoral challenges like antimicrobial resistance, climate change, re-emerging diseases, and lifestyle diseases, making a stronger WHO necessary.

Incorrect Options:
b) The passage does not state that WHO should replace national agencies.
c) WHO funding is actually under threat from U.S. withdrawal.
d) The passage does not mention that developed nations have fully withdrawn.

5.
Ans: b
Explanation:
Reference: "This is partially true and to be fair in assessment, every global institution needs some reforms and WHO is not any different. In fact, there is far more to WHO's credit than the occasional systemic blips it has faced."

The passage suggests that while WHO has some bureaucratic issues, it deserves credit for its contributions, and every global institution needs some reforms.

Incorrect Options:

a) The passage does not mention comparing WHO with other health organizations.
c) A fair assessment should not focus only on its inefficiencies.
d) The passage does not suggest that each nation should decide WHO's role.

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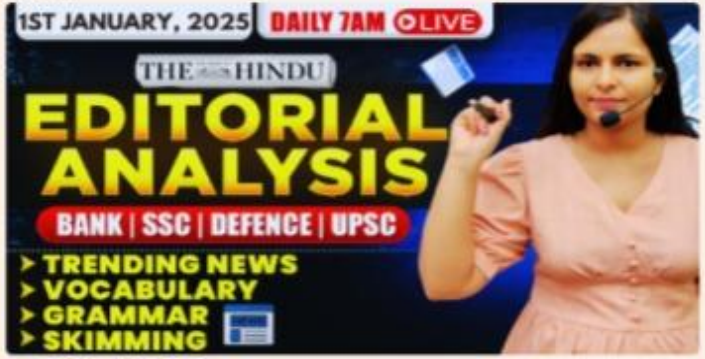

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